

African nationalism gathers pace during the early 1900s.

The ideology of **Pan-Africanism** gains adherents worldwide.

African experiences in **World War II** spur demands for **racial equality**.

Nkrumah wins independence for Ghana.

Nkrumah fails in his campaign for the **political unity** of Africa.

By the mid-1970s, most of Africa has gained **independence**, if not peace.

to Kenya, Northern Rhodesia (Zambia), Nyasaland (Malawi), and Uganda.

The French fought an eight-year war to hold on to Algeria, finally conceding independence in 1962.

The Portuguese, the first European colonial power in Africa, fought a long war to hold on to their colonies of Angola, Mozambique, and Guinea from 1961 to 1974. The collapse of Belgian authority in the Congo in 1960 led to a wave of violence across the nation and the assassination of the first prime minister, Patrice Lumumba, in 1961.

Many African countries gained independence during the Cold War. Used as pawns between the capitalist and communist superpowers, they accepted loans and military aid: in the 1970s, Ethiopia was rewarded with billions of

dollars' worth of Soviet military equipment. Civil wars were also numerous, such as the ethnic civil wars in Rwanda and Zaire, as well as the clashes between warlords over food supplies in Somalia.

Dictatorial rulers

Once independence was achieved, African nationalist leaders sought to consolidate power by banning political rivals. Coups and military governments predominated—such as that of Idi Amin in Uganda. By the early 1970s, only Zimbabwe and South Africa were still ruled by the white political elite. Corruption, however, existed in most African countries. Nkrumah wanted Ghana to be a beacon of success, but his Pan-Africanism failed, and Ghana's fortunes began to slide as he became increasingly dictatorial. ■

Kwame Nkrumah



Ambitious and well-educated, Kwame Nkrumah had big plans for both Ghana and Africa as a whole. He went to

college in the US and later traveled to England, where he became involved in the West African Students' Union. In 1948, he began traveling around the Gold Coast as leader of a youth movement calling for "self-government now."

Nkrumah's calls for positive action civil disobedience as head of the Convention People's Party led to his arrest, and he was sentenced to three years in jail. While in prison, he won the general election, and

five years later, in 1957, he became prime minister of the newly independent Ghana.

Nkrumah's popularity rose with the construction of new schools, roads, and health facilities, but by 1964 Ghana was a one-party state and Nkrumah its "life president." After two assassination attempts and increasing human-rights abuses, Nkrumah faced a coup in 1966 and went into exile in Guinea. He died of cancer in 1972.